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Managing an app, for example developing an app comprising updating a workflow of the app, method, and system

Abstract

For an improved management of an app (120), a computer-implemented method is suggested comprising: •capturing the user's intent to insert an additional workflow artifact (122a) into the workflow (124) in response to user interactions with the app development UI (116); •inserting the additional workflow artifact (122a) to the workflow (124) according into the captured user's intent; •determining an overlap (126) of at least two of the workflow artifacts (122) caused by the inserted workflow artifact (122a); •determining a flow direction (128) of the workflow (124) from the preceding workflow artifact (122p) to the following workflow artifact (122f), the preceding and the following workflow artifact (122p, 122f) preceding and following the inserted workflow artifact (122a), respectively; •determining at least one workflow artifact (122m) of the workflow (124) which needs to be moved along the determined flow direction (128) to avoid the determined overlap (126); •determining an updated workflow (124') by moving the respective, determined workflow artifact (122m) along the determined flow direction (128) at least until the determined overlap (126) is removed; •displaying at least the preceding workflow artifact (122p), the inserted workflow artifact (122a), and the following workflow artifact (122f) to the user in the app development UI (116); and •developing the app (120) through the app development UI (116) by using the updated workflow (124').

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Background/Summary

CROSS REFERENCE TO RELATED APPLICATIONS

(1) The present patent document is a § 371 nationalization of PCT Application Serial Number PCT/EP2021/087262, filed Dec. 22, 2021, designating the United States which is hereby incorporated in its entirety by reference.

FIELD

(2) The present disclosure is directed, in general, to software management systems, for example systems for developing apps, that may be used to manage, build, test, deploy and iterate such apps (collectively referred to herein as product systems).

BACKGROUND

(3) Recently, an increasing number of computer software products are used both for personal needs and for business needs in the form of applications, throughout the present document simply called "apps". Such apps may be used in a mobile context as well as on cloud computing platforms and "on premise" and may provide a specific set of functions.

(4) Currently, there exist product systems and solutions which support managing or developing such apps. Such product systems may benefit from improvements.

BRIEF SUMMARY AND DESCRIPTION

(5) Embodiments provide methods and computer systems that may be used to facilitate managing an app.

(6) According to a first aspect, a computer-implemented method of managing an app may include: providing an app development user interface (UI) to a user for developing the app; displaying at least two workflow artifacts of a workflow of the app to the user in the app development UI; capturing the user's intent to insert an additional workflow artifact into the workflow in response to user interactions with the app development UI; inserting the additional workflow artifact into the workflow according to the captured user's intent; determining an overlap of at least two of the workflow artifacts caused by the inserted workflow artifact; determining a flow direction of the workflow from the preceding workflow artifact to the following workflow artifact, the preceding and the following workflow artifact preceding and following the inserted workflow artifact,

respectively; determining at least one workflow artifact of the workflow which needs to be moved along the determined flow direction to avoid the determined overlap; determining an updated workflow by moving the respective, determined workflow artifact in the direction of the determined flow direction at least until the determined overlap is removed; displaying at least the preceding workflow artifact, the inserted workflow artifact and the following workflow artifact to the user in the app development UI; and developing the app through the app development UI by using the updated workflow; determining a moving borderline in the workflow. A moving borderline intersects the preceding workflow artifact and is perpendicular to the determined flow direction; and determining an updated workflow by only moving one or more workflow artifacts which are arranged in the workflow at the same side of the moving borderline as the inserted artifact or the removed workflow artifact.

(7) According to a second aspect, a computer system may be arranged and configured to execute the steps of this computer-implemented method of managing an app. For example, the described computer system may be arranged and configured to execute the following steps: providing an app development user interface (UI) to a user for developing the app; displaying at least two workflow artifacts of a workflow of the app to the user in the app development UI; capturing the user's intent to insert an additional workflow artifact into the workflow in response to user interactions with the app development UI; inserting the additional workflow artifact into the workflow according to the captured user's intent; determining an overlap of at least two of the workflow artifacts caused by the inserted workflow artifact; determining a flow direction of the workflow from the preceding workflow artifact to the following workflow artifact, the preceding and the following workflow artifact preceding and following the inserted workflow artifact, respectively; determining at least one workflow artifact of the workflow which needs to be moved along the determined flow direction to avoid the determined overlap; determining an updated workflow by moving the respective, determined workflow artifact in the direction of the determined flow direction at least until the determined overlap is removed; displaying at least the preceding workflow artifact, the inserted workflow artifact, and the following workflow artifact to the user in the app development UI; and developing the app through the app development UI by using the updated workflow; determining a moving borderline in the workflow. The moving borderline intersects the preceding workflow artifact and is perpendicular to the determined flow direction; and determining an updated workflow by only moving one or more workflow artifacts which are arranged in the workflow at the same side of the moving borderline as the inserted artifact or the removed workflow artifact.

(8) According to a third aspect, a computer program product may include computer program code which, when executed by a computer system, cause the computer system to carry out this computer-implemented method of managing an app.

(9) According to a fourth aspect, a computer-readable medium may include computer program code which, when executed by a computer system, cause the computer system to carry out this computer-implemented method of managing an app. By way of example, the described computer-readable medium may be non-transitory and may further be a software component on a storage device.

(10) In some examples, the mentioned app development platform may be a visual model-based and/or low-code app development platform which is described in more detail below.

(11) The foregoing has outlined rather broadly the technical features of the present disclosure so that those skilled in the art may better understand the detailed description that follows. Additional features and advantages of the disclosure will be described hereinafter that form the subject of the claims. Those skilled in the art will appreciate that they may readily use the conception and the specific embodiments disclosed as a basis for modifying or designing other structures for carrying out the same purposes of the present disclosure. Those skilled in the art will also realize that such equivalent constructions do not depart from the spirit and scope of the disclosure in its broadest

form.

(12) Also, before undertaking the detailed description below, it should be understood that various definitions for certain words and phrases are provided throughout this patent document and those of ordinary skill in the art will understand that such definitions apply in many, if not most, instances to prior as well as future uses of such defined words and phrases. While some terms may include a wide variety of embodiments, the appended claims may expressly limit these terms to specific embodiments.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE FIGURES

- (1) FIGS. 1-2 depict a functional block diagram of an example system that facilitates managing an app in a product system according to an embodiment.
- (2) FIG. 3-10 depict a flow diagram of an example methodology that facilitates managing an app in a product system according to an embodiment.
- (3) FIG. 11 depicts a block diagram of a data processing system in which an embodiment may be implemented.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

(4) Various technologies that pertain to systems and methods for managing apps, for example developing an app including updating a workflow of the app, in a product system are described with reference to the drawings, where like reference numerals represent like elements throughout. The drawings discussed below, and the various embodiments used to describe the principles of the present disclosure in this patent document are by way of illustration only and should not be construed in any way to limit the scope of the disclosure. Those skilled in the art will understand that the principles of the present disclosure may be implemented in any suitably arranged apparatus. It is to be understood that functionality that is described as being carried out by certain system elements may be performed by multiple elements. Similarly, for instance, an element may be configured to perform functionality that is described as being carried out by multiple elements. The numerous innovative teachings of the present patent document will be described with reference to exemplary non-limiting embodiments.

(5) An app generally refers to a software program which on execution performs specific desired tasks. In general, several apps are executed in a runtime environment containing one or more operating systems (“OSs”), virtual machines (e.g., supporting Java™ programming language), device drivers, etc.

(6) Apps, including native apps, may be created, edited, and represented using traditional source code. Examples of such traditional source code include C, C++, Java, Flash, Python, Perl, and other script-based methods of representing an app. Developing, creating, and managing such script-based apps, or parts of such script-based apps may be accomplished by manual coding of suitably trained users.

(7) Developers often use Application Development Frameworks (“ADFs”) (which are by themselves applications or apps) for implementing/developing desired apps. An ADF provides a set of pre-defined code/data modules that may be directly/indirectly used in the development of an app. An ADF may also provide tools such as an Integrated Development Environment (“IDE”), code generators, debuggers, etc. that facilitate a developer in coding/implementing the desired logic of the app in a faster/simpler manner.

(8) In general, an ADF simplifies app development by providing reusable components that may be used by app developers to define user interfaces (“UIs”) and app logic by, for example, selecting components to perform desired tasks and defining the appearance, behavior, and interactions of the selected components. Some ADFs are based on a model-view-controller design pattern that

promotes loose coupling and easier app development and maintenance.

(9) According to another approach, apps may also be created, edited, and represented using visual model-based representations. Unlike traditional source code implementations, such apps may be created, edited, and/or represented by drawing, moving, connecting, and/or disconnecting visual depictions of logical elements within a visual modeling environment. Visual model-based representations of apps may use symbols, shapes, lines, colors, shades, animations, and/or other visual elements to represent logic, data or memory structures or user interface elements. In order to program a traditional script-based app, programmers are typically required to type out detailed scripts according to a complicated set of programming syntax rules. In contrast, programming a visual model-based app may, in some cases, be done by connecting various logical elements (e.g., action blocks and/or decision blocks) to create a visual flow chart that defines the app's operation. Similarly, defining data structures (e.g., variable types, database objects, or classes) and/or user interface elements (e.g., dropdown boxes, lists, text input boxes) in a visual model-based app may be done by drawing, placing, or connecting visual depictions of logical elements within a virtual workspace, as opposed to typing out detailed commands in a script. Visual-model based apps, including native apps, may therefore be more intuitive to program and/or edit compared to traditional script-based apps. In the present document, an approach is suggested to manage apps, for example to develop an app including a trained function, that may involve the explained visual model-based representations.

(10) For brevity, references to a “model,” a “visual model,” or an “application” or “app” should be understood to refer to visual model-based apps, including native apps, unless specifically indicated. In some cases, such visual model-based apps may represent complete, stand-alone apps for execution on a computer system. Visual model-based apps may also represent discrete modules that are configured to perform certain tasks or functions, but that do not represent complete apps—instead, such discrete modules may be inserted into a larger app or combined with other discrete modules to perform more complicated tasks. Examples of such discrete modules may include modules for validating a ZIP code, for receiving information regarding current weather from a weather feed, and/or for rendering graphics.

(11) Visual models may be represented in two forms: an internal representation and one or more associated visual representations. The internal representation may be a file encoded according to a file format used by a modeling environment to capture and define the operation of an app (or part of an app). For example, the internal representation may define what inputs an app may receive, what outputs an app may provide, the algorithms and operations by which the app may arrive at results, what data the app may display, what data the app may store, etc. The internal representation may also be used to instruct an execution environment how to execute the logic of the app during run-time. Internal representations may be stored in the form of non-human-readable code (e.g., binary code). Internal representations may also be stored according to a binary stored JSON (java script object notation) format, and/or an XML format. At run-time, an execution engine may use an internal representation to compile and/or generate executable machine code that, when executed by a processor, causes the processor to implement the functionality of the model.

(12) The internal representation may be associated with one or more visual representations. Visual representations may include visual elements that depict how an app's logic flows, but which are not configured to be compiled or executed. The visual representations may include, for example, flow-charts or decision trees that show a user how the app will operate. The visual models may also visually depict data that is to be received from the user, data that is to be stored, and data that is to be displayed to the user. The visual models may also be interactive, that allows a user to manipulate the model in an intuitive way. For example, visual representations may be configured to display a certain level of detail (e.g., number of branches, number of displayed parameters, granularity of displayed logic) by default. However, users may interact with the visual representation in order to show a desired level of detail—for example, users may display or hide branches of logic, and/or

display or hide sets of parameters. Details relating to an element of the visual model may be hidden from view by default but may appear in a sliding window or pop-up that appears on-screen when the user clicks on the appropriate element. Users may also zoom in or out of the model, and/or pan across different parts of the model, to examine different parts of the model. Users may also copy or paste branches of logic from one section of the model into another section, or copy/paste branches of logic from a first model into a second model. In some cases, parts of the model may contain links to other parts of the model, such that if a user clicks on a link, the user will automatically be led to another part of the model. A viewing user may interact with a visual representation in at least some of the same ways that the viewing user might interact with the model if it were displayed within a modeling environment. In other words, the visual representation may be configured to mimic how the model might appear if it were displayed within a visual modeling environment. A single internal representation may correspond to multiple visual representations that use different styles or formatting rules to display app logic. For instance, multiple visual representations corresponding to the same internal representation may differ from one another in their use of color, elements that are included or omitted, and use of symbols, shapes, lines, colors, and/or shades to depict logic flow.

(13) Approaches involving the above-described functionalities of visual model-based representations, visual model-based apps, and/or visual models are sometimes understood to be included by a so-called low-code application development platform or low-code app development platform. By way of example, such a low-code application development platform may further be described as software that provides a development environment used to create application software through graphical user interfaces and configuration instead of traditional hand-coded computer programming. A low-code model may enable developers of varied experience levels to create applications using a visual user interface in combination with model-driven logic. Such low-code application development platforms may produce entirely operational apps or require additional coding for specific situations. Low-code app development platforms may reduce the amount of traditional hand coding, enabling accelerated delivery of business apps. A common benefit is that a wider range of people may contribute to the app's development—not only those with formal programming skills. Low-code app development platforms may also lower the initial cost of setup, training, deployment, and maintenance.

(14) With reference to FIG. 1, a functional block diagram of an example computer system or data processing system **100** is depicted that facilitates managing apps **120**, for example developing an app **120** including updating a workflow **124** of the app **120**. The processing system **100** may include a (visual model-based) app development platform **118** including at least one processor **102** that is configured to execute at least one application software component **106** from a memory **104** accessed by the processor **102**. Herein, the app development platform **118** may include the above-described functionalities of visual model-based representations, visual model-based apps, and/or visual models and, by way of example, be a visual model-based app development platform or a low-code app development platform. The application software component **106** may be configured (i.e., programmed) to cause the processor **102** to carry out various acts and functions described herein. For example, the described application software component **106** may include and/or correspond to one or more components of an app development application that is configured to generate and store product data in a data store **108** such as a database. Furthermore, the described application software component **106** may include and/or correspond to one or more components of an app creation or development application.

(15) By way of example, the app development platform **118** may be cloud-based, internet-based and/or be operated by a provider providing app development and creation support, including e.g., supporting low-code and/or visual model-based app development. The user may be located close to the app development platform **118** or remote to the app development platform **118**, e.g., anywhere else, e.g., using a mobile device for connecting to the app development platform **118**, e.g., via the

internet. The mobile device may include an input device **110** and a display device **112**. In some examples, the app development platform **118** may be installed and run on a user's device, such as a computer, laptop, pad, on-premises computing facility, or the like.

(16) Examples of product systems that may be adapted to include the app management and/or development including updating a workflow of the app features described herein may include the low-code software development platform of Mendix Inc., of Boston, Massachusetts, USA. This platform provides tools to build, test, deploy, iterate, develop, create, and manage apps **120** and is based on visual, model-driven software development. However, the systems and methods described herein may be used in other product systems (e.g., product lifecycle management (PLM), product data management (PDM), application lifecycle management (ALM) systems) and/or any other type of system that generates and stores product data in a database. Also, examples of databases that may be used as one or more data stores described herein include database server applications such as Oracle, Microsoft SQL Server, or any other type of data store that is operative to store data records.

(17) It may be difficult and time-consuming to manage apps **120**, for example developing an app **120** including updating a workflow **124** of the app **120**, in complex app development and/or management environments. For example, advanced coding or software development or management knowledge of users may be required, or selections of many options need to be made consciously, both involving many manual steps, that is a long and not efficient process.

(18) To enable the enhanced management apps **120**, for example developing an app **120** including updating a workflow **124** of the app **120**, the described product system or processing system **100** may include at least one input device **110** and at least one display device **112** (such as a display screen). The described processor **102** may be configured to generate a graphical user interface (GUI) **114** through the display device **112**. Such a GUI **114** may include GUI elements such as buttons, links, search boxes, lists, text boxes, images, scroll bars usable by a user to provide inputs through the input device **110** that cause updating the workflow **124** and/or developing the app **120**. By way of example, the GUI **114** may include an app development UI **116** provided to a user for developing the app **120**.

(19) In an example embodiment, the application software component **106** and/or the processor **102** may be configured to provide an app development user interface (UI) **116** of an app development platform **118** to a user for developing the app **120**.

(20) As mentioned above, the app development platform **118** may include the above-described functionalities of visual model-based representations, visual model-based apps, and/or visual models and, by way of example, be a visual model-based app development platform or a low-code app development platform. The app development UI **116** may provide an interactive user interface of the app development platform **118** that supports and enables the user to develop the app **120**. By way of example, the app **120** may be or include a software program which on execution performs specific desired tasks.

(21) In some examples, the application software component **106** and/or the processor **102** may further be configured to display at least two workflow artifacts **122** of a workflow **124** of the app **120** to the user in the app development UI **116**.

(22) Herein, a workflow **124** may generally be considered to include an orchestrated and repeatable pattern of activity, enabled by the systematic organization of resources into processes that may transform materials, provide services, or process information. A workflow **124** may be depicted as a sequence of operations, the work of a person or group, the work of an organization of staff, or one or more simple or complex mechanisms. In the context of apps **120** and the development of apps **120**, the workflow **124** may describe or characterize the pattern of activity that may be executed by the developed and deployed app **120**. The workflow **124** may, in some sense, express a logic of the app **120**. Hence, executing the workflow **124** that may correspond to the given business logic, and that may be included by the developed and deployed app **120** may contribute to fulfill a certain

business need. In some examples, the workflow **124** may include two or more workflow artifacts **122** that may form the mentioned pattern, and that may correspond to single activities of the mentioned pattern.

(23) In some app development platforms **118**, such a workflow **124** may be known as a microflow or a nanoflow. Like workflows **124** of apps **120** in general, such microflows or a nanoflows may perform actions, e.g., the above-mentioned workflow artifacts **122**, such as creating and updating objects, showing pages, and making choices. Such choices may be decisions, i.e., e.g., workflow artifacts **122** that may make a choice based on a condition and follow one and only one of the outgoing paths. For example, for an app **120** in the context of onboarding new hires, you need to use a decision to follow different paths when a new hire works remotely or when they work from the office. In an industrial context, the app **120** may include a decision on whether to stop the production process of a device, e.g., a production machine, e.g., based on input data **152** of the device, such as condition monitoring data or status data relating to the device. In some examples, the mentioned device may correspond to the below mentioned target device **150** or other device. Such decision workflow artifacts **122** may, e.g., include an exclusive split that is an element that makes a choice based on a condition and follows (exactly) one of the outgoing sequence flows. Such decision workflow artifacts **122** may, e.g., further include an inheritance split that is an element that makes a choice based on the type of a certain variable. For each specialization of the variable, the workflow **124** may continue in a different way. Further, such decision workflow artifacts **122** may, e.g., include a parallel split that may be used to have parallel processes in your workflow **124**. Such parallel processes or the above-mentioned outgoing sequence flows may also be understood as partial flows **142** of a workflow **124** that are explained below. For example, when onboarding a new employee, you may have several processes running in parallel: the human resources department preparing necessary documents, the IT department preparing a workstation, and the administration department scheduling a training for the employee. In some examples, such decision workflow artifacts **122** may be understood as a split artifact **140** that is explained below.

(24) Accordingly, there may be workflow artifacts **122** that may merge processes running in parallel or which combine multiple sequence flows into one sequence flow. There may, e.g., be situations where the workflow **124** has been separated in the part preceding the merge to execute specific actions. After this, the same action needs to be executed for all the separated flows. In this situation a merge may be used to avoid redundancy. In some examples, such merge workflow artifacts **122** may be understood as a merge artifact **148** that is explained below, and that merges partial flows **142**.

(25) For example in the context of low code app development, the workflow **124** may be understood as a visual way of expressing what traditionally ends up in textual program code.

(26) In some app development platforms **118**, microflows may run in the runtime server and may therefore, in some examples, not be used in offline apps, while nanoflows may run directly on the browser or the target device **150** and may, in some examples, be used in an offline app.

Furthermore, most of the actions in nanoflows may run directly on the target device **150**, so there may also be a speed benefit for logic that does not need access to the server.

(27) By way of example, the workflow artifacts **122** may correspond to one or more activities executed by the app **120**, e.g., accessing input data **152**, manipulating the input data **152**, generating output data **154**, user interactions, such as capturing queries of the app user, displaying data, e.g., input data **152** or output data **154** to the app user, or transmitting the output data **154** to some other app or device, e.g., the device connected to the target device **150**. The workflow artifacts **122** may further relate, as already mentioned above, to creating and updating objects, showing pages, and making choices.

(28) In further examples, the application software component **106** and/or the processor **102** may further be configured to capture the user's intent to insert an additional workflow artifact **122a** into the workflow **124** in response to user interactions with the app development UI **116**.

(29) E.g., for the purposes of further developing the app **120**, the user may want to insert an additional workflow artifact **122a** into the workflow **124**. The user may, in some examples, express their intent by dragging and dropping the additional workflow artifact **122a** in the workflow **124** displayed in the app development UI **116**. This may be done, e.g., by dragging and dropping the additional workflow artifact **122** between two neighboring workflow artifacts **122** or on one of the workflow artifacts **122**, for example, using the input device **110**. Herein, in some examples, the additional workflow artifact **122a** may be an additional action that the user wants to insert in the existing workflow **124** of the app **120** that he or she develops.

(30) In further examples, the additional workflow artifact **122a** may be chosen from a library or from templates that are made available to the user by the app development platform **118** and/or that may be created by the user and/or that may be imported by the user from somewhere else, e.g., from other data sources available in the internet.

(31) In some examples, the user intent may be to move one of the workflow artifacts **122** of the workflow **124** from an initial position to a final position within the workflow **124**. This user intent may be understood as deleting this specific workflow artifact **122** at the initial position from the workflow **124** and inserting the specific workflow artifact **122** at the final position in the workflow **124**. Herein, the insertion of this specific workflow artifact **122** at the final position in the workflow **124** may be understood as inserting this specific workflow artifact **122** as the additional workflow artifact **122a** into the workflow **124** at the final position. The resulting overlap **126** at the final position may then be removed according to the approach described below.

(32) By way of example, the application software component **106** and/or the processor **102** may further be configured to insert the additional workflow artifact **122a** into the workflow **124** according to the captured user's intent.

(33) The app development platform **118** may then put the additional workflow artifact **122a** in the workflow **124** as desired by the user. In some examples, the previously defined workflow **124** may not yet be rearranged to accommodate the additional workflow artifact **122a**. In further examples, if the additional workflow artifact **122a** is inserted between a preceding workflow artifact **122p** and a following workflow artifact **122f**, the additional workflow artifact **122a** may be put at the initial position of the following workflow artifact **122f** or in the vicinity the initial position of the following workflow artifact **122f**, e.g., towards the preceding workflow artifact **122p**, to obtain the amended workflow **124'**.

(34) In some examples, the application software component **106** and/or the processor **102** may further be configured to determine an overlap **126** of at least two of the workflow artifacts **122** caused by the inserted workflow artifact **122a**.

(35) Generally, inserting the additional workflow artifact **122a** may lead to an overlap **126** of workflow artifacts **122** of the workflow **124** that now includes the inserted workflow artifact **122a** as well. Herein, an overlap **126** may be understood as one of the workflow artifacts **122**, **122a** of the workflow **124** to extend over or past and cover a part of another workflow artifact **122**, **122a** of the workflow **124**. The respective overlapping workflow artifacts **122**, **122a** may have the size as displayed to the user in the app development UI **116** or the respective overlapping workflow artifacts **122**, **122a** may have a larger size than displayed in the app development UI **116**.

Therefore, in some examples, the respective overlapping workflow artifacts **122**, **122a** may also overlap when displayed on the app development UI **116**. In other examples, the respective overlapping workflow artifacts **122**, **122a** may be displayed in the app development UI **116** to be closer to each other than other, neighboring workflow artifacts **122**. In such examples, the respective overlapping workflow artifacts **122**, **122a** may be displayed in the app development UI **116** as not overlapping although they do overlap since the respective overlapping workflow artifacts **122**, **122a** may have a larger size, respectively, than displayed in the app development UI **116**.

(36) In most examples, the inserted workflow artifact **122a** may at least partly overlap with one of

the workflow artifacts **122** that was already included by the workflow **124** prior to the insertion of the inserted workflow artifact **122a**.

(37) In further examples, the application software component **106** and/or the processor **102** may further be configured to determine a flow direction **128** of the workflow **124** from the preceding workflow artifact **122p** to the following workflow artifact **122f**, the preceding and the following workflow artifact **122p**, **122f** preceding and following the inserted workflow artifact **122a**, respectively.

(38) In some examples, the workflow **124** may be characterized by certain flow direction **128** linking the preceding workflow artifact **122p** with the following workflow artifact **122f**. The flow direction **128** may indicate the flow of workflow artifacts **122** and may, e.g., define that the preceding workflow artifact **122p** may be executed before the following workflow artifact **122f** may be executed. By way of example, the flow direction **128** may be indicated with arrows in the app development UI **116**.

(39) Hence, the flow direction **128** or sequence flow may, in some examples, be understood as a flow that may be shown in the app development UI **116** using one or more arrows that link(s) the workflow artifacts **122**, such as events, activities, decisions, etc., with each other. Hereby, the flow direction **128** may define the order of execution. The flow direction **128** may generally flow in one direction where workflow artifacts **122** follow each other up one by one. When two activities or workflow artifacts **122** shall be linked together, the flow direction **128** or a sequence flow may be used.

(40) For the sake of clarity, the flow direction **128** may link the proceeding workflow artifact **122p** and the following workflow artifact **122f** such that first, the proceeding workflow artifact **122p** is executed and then, the following workflow artifact **122f** is executed.

(41) By way of example, the application software component **106** and/or the processor **102** may further be configured to determine at least one workflow artifact **122m** of the workflow **124** that needs to be moved along the determined flow direction **128** to avoid the determined overlap **126**.

(42) The determination of the workflow artifact(s) **122m** to be moved may involve the determination if the determined overlap **126** may be removed by moving a corresponding workflow artifact **122** of the workflow **124** along the determined flow direction **128**. If the determined overlap may be removed by moving the respective workflow artifact **122**, this respective workflow artifact **122** may be identified as the workflow artifact **122m** to be moved. In many cases, the workflow artifact **122m** to be moved may be the following workflow artifact **122f**, i.e., the workflow artifact **122f** that is following the inserted artifact **122a** in the workflow **124** after the insertion of the inserted workflow **122a**. In some examples, the workflow artifact **122m** to be moved may be the preceding workflow artifact **122p**, i.e., the workflow artifact **122p** that is preceding the inserted artifact **122a** in the workflow **124** after the insertion of the inserted workflow **122a**.

(43) In further examples, the application software component **106** and/or the processor **102** may further be configured to determine an updated workflow **124'** by moving the respective, determined workflow artifact **122m** along the determined flow direction **128** at least until the determined overlap **126** is removed.

(44) The determined workflow artifact **122m** to be moved may then be moved in the workflow **124** along the determined flow direction **128** at least until the determined overlap **126** is removed to obtain an updated workflow **124'**. Generally, by way of example, the movement of the determined workflow artifact **122m** may be stopped as soon as the determined overlap **126** is removed. Moving the determined workflow artifact **122m** may sometimes be called nudging since the determined workflow artifact **122m** may only gently or gradually be moved, but also since this approach tries to keep the general layout of the workflow **124**.

(45) By way of example, the application software component **106** and/or the processor **102** may further be configured to display at least the preceding workflow artifact **122p**, the inserted

workflow artifact **122a**, and the following workflow artifact **122f** to the user in the app development UI **116**.

(46) Herein, in some examples, the preceding workflow artifact **122p**, the inserted workflow artifact **122a**, and the following workflow artifact **122f** may be displayed to the user after the insertion of the inserted workflow artifact **122a** and after moving the determined workflow artifact **122m** to obtain the updated workflow **124'**. In other words, at least the three mentioned workflow artifacts **122p**, **122a**, **122f** of the updated workflow **124'** may be displayed to the user in the app development UI **116**.

(47) Displaying the proceeding workflow artifact **122p**, the inserted workflow artifact **122a**, and the following workflow artifact **122f** in the app development UI **116**, may allow the user to retrace the amendments made to the original workflow **124** to obtain the updated workflow **124'** and to check the updated workflow **124'**. In some examples, the user may confirm or discard the updated workflow **124'** by corresponding user interactions with the app development UI **116**. The suggested update mechanism of the workflow **124** to obtain the updated workflow **124'** may provide very good results that may both comply with the user's insert intent and provide an updated workflow **124'** that may readily be used by the app development platform **118** to create or develop the app **120**.

(48) In further examples, the application software component **106** and/or the processor **102** may further be configured to develop the app **120** through the app development UI **116** by using the updated workflow **124'**.

(49) Using the updated workflow **124'**, the app **120** may be developed through the app development UI **116** that may interact, by way of example, with an ADF, IDE, visual model-based representations or the above-mentioned (low-code) app development platform **118** to accomplish the development of the app **120**. Herein, the app development platform **118** together with the updated workflow **124'** may be suitable to support non-expert users to insert the additional workflow artifacts **122** in the workflow and then to develop the app **120** including the updated workflow **124'**.

(50) The suggested method may be suitable to preserve the layout of the workflow **124** to obtain the updated workflow **124'** after the insertion of the additional workflow artifact **122a**. This may e.g., be achieved by avoiding overlapping workflow artifacts **122**, by avoiding crossing flows in the workflow **124**, by avoiding resetting the user's layout of the workflow **124**, and/or by allowing for future expansion of the workflow **124**, e.g., by introducing decision splits, loops, etc.

(51) Hence, the suggested method may make sure that an updated workflow **124'** may be obtained that may be interpreted by the app development platform **118** in a meaningful and consistent way. Therefore, the suggested method may avoid contradictions and broken or crossing flows in the updated workflow **124'** that may lead to inconsistencies and issues when the app development platform **118** tries to develop or create the app **120** based on such an inconsistent or contradictory, updated workflow **124'**. The suggested method may consequently considerably help to facilitate the app development, for example, for non-expert app developers.

(52) Other approaches, e.g., relating to macro layout algorithms, such as dot, twopi, neato or the Sugiyama algorithm, may tend to rewrite the entire graph layout that may have severe drawbacks. For example, a user, esp. a non-expert app developer, might not recognize their initial workflow **124** anymore and might get lost during the development of their app **120**. This might hinder further amendments, such as the insertion of yet further workflow artifact **122** to the workflow **124**, that, however, is regularly required many times during the development of a workflow **124** of an app **120** or of an app **120**.

(53) Further, according to yet other approaches, the user may take care of the layout of the workflow **124** themselves to obtain the updated workflow **124'** after the insertion of the additional workflow artifact **122a**. This approach, however, may involve many manual steps, e.g., involving manual coding, that may only be performed by suitably trained users. Also, this approach is time-

consuming and error-prone.

(54) Contrary to these other approaches, the suggested method may embody a sort of low-code approach for a user to create a logic layout of the workflow **124** and to develop the app **120**. Particularly, the suggested method may take away the burden from the user to manually amend or correct a workflow logic when adding, but also when moving or deleting workflow artifacts **122** in a workflow **124**. Advantages of the suggested approach include visually displaying to the user what is amended by the suggested update of the workflow **124**. Hence, the user may still keep the control of the applied changes, also since according the suggested approach, only small changes may be done to the workflow **124** that is hence corresponding to a “micro” aspect opposed to the above-mentioned macro layout algorithms.

(55) It should further be appreciated, that the suggested approach may be applicable to the above-mentioned app development platforms **118** that provide workflows **124** as a microflows or a nanoflows.

(56) in some examples, the application software component **106** and/or the processor **102** may further be configured to determine a moving borderline **146** in the workflow **124**. The moving borderline **146** intersects the preceding workflow artifact **122_p** and is perpendicular to the determined flow direction **128**; and to determine an updated workflow **124'** by only moving one or more workflow artifacts **122** that are arranged in the workflow **124** at the same side of the moving borderline **146** as the inserted artifact **122_a** or the removed workflow artifact **122_r**.

(57) The use of the described moving borderline **146** may be advantageous for more complex or advanced workflows **124**. Such more complex workflows **124** may include curves at which workflow artifacts **122** may be arranged so that the workflow **124** may cross or intersect the determined moving borderline **146** once or several times. For example, a workflow **124** with an S-shape or a Z-shape. The moving borderline may be a vertical line that splits this workflow **124** into the right half and the left half. Such a workflow **124** crosses or intersect this moving borderline **146** three times, namely at the top, at the middle and at the bottom of the shape of the workflow **124**.

(58) The moving borderline **146** may be determined to intersect the workflow **124** at the preceding workflow artifact **122_p** and may be perpendicular to the determined flow direction **128**. The updated workflow **124'** may then be determined by only moving artifacts **122** that are arranged at the same side of the moving borderline **146** as the inserted workflow artifact **122_a** or the removed workflow artifact **122_r**. In other words, in some examples, workflow artifacts that are arranged at the same side of the moving borderline **146** as the preceding workflow artifact **122_p** may not be moved.

(59) This rather simple approach may turn out to be very efficient and failsafe. It is rather easy to implement and yet considerably contributes to preserve the layout of the workflow **124**.

(60) In some examples, the workflow **124** may intersect the determined moving borderline **146** at least twice. The workflow **124** may include an S-shape or a Z-shape, as explained above, or the workflow **124** may include a U-shape as depicted in FIG. 5 and explained below.

(61) In further examples, the application software component **106** and/or the processor **102** may further be configured to determine at least one position **130** in the workflow **124** at which to insert the additional workflow artifact **122_a** using the captured user's intent and a trained function **132**.

(62) A trained function **132** may, e.g., be understood to be or include a machine learning algorithm, a deep learning model, an artificial neural network or more generally an artificial intelligence-based function. Alternative terms for “artificial neural network” are “neural network”, “artificial neural net” or “neural net” and an example may be a convolutional neural network.

(63) The trained function **132** may receive data input that is then processed using the trained function **132** to generate data output. in some examples, the trained function **132** may be used for pattern recognition, data mining, image recognition, speech recognition, etc., and may be useful for processing large amounts of data.

(64) In the present context, the trained function **132** may, in some examples, include a

recommendation engine that may make a recommendation or several recommendations to the user with respect to a position **130** or several different positions **130** in the workflow at which to insert the additional workflow artifact **122a** into the workflow **124**. Herein, the mentioned data input may include data on one or more meaningful positions **130** for inserting respective additional workflow artifacts **122a** into workflows **124**. The data input may, in some examples, originate from users that have previously amended their respective workflow **124** by inserting additional workflow artifacts **122a** to create or develop respective apps **120**. In some examples, only such input data may be considered in which the amended workflow **124'** resulted in a successfully developed and deployed app **120**. The trained function **132** may use such data input, process the data input, and then output data output including one or more recommended positions **130** at which the user of the currently developed workflow **124** and app **120** may insert the currently inserted workflow artifact **122a**.

(65) In other examples, the user may initially only provide a certain desired functionality of the app **120** and the trained function **132** may then determine the additional workflow artifact **122a** that needs to be inserted into the workflow **124** and that corresponds best to the functionality desired by the user. In such more advanced examples, the trained function **132** may therefore sort of translate the captured user's intent to insert the desired functionality into the required additional workflow artifact **122a**. Herein, the corresponding data input may, in some examples, originate from users that have previously input a desired functionality and inserted additional workflow items **122a** into the workflow to (successfully) create or develop respective apps **120**.

(66) The suggested update mechanism of the workflow **124** after the insertion of the additional workflow item **122a** may support both a regular, non-expert app developer user and a user who is supported by the trained function **132**. In some examples, the trained function **132** may very quickly and conveniently determine the suitable position **130** at which the additional workflow artifact **122a** shall be inserted. However, in many cases, the trained function **132** or some other artificial intelligence-based function may not be able to update the workflow **124** in a meaningful way. Hence, the trained function **132** may be limited to only determine the right position **130** for the insertion of the additional workflow artifact **122a** but may not carry out the subsequent step of suitably updating, rearranging or reordering the workflow **124** after the insertion of the additional workflow artifact **122a**. In many examples, a workflow **124** established only by regular, non-expert app developer users supported by the trained function **132** or some other artificial intelligence-based function but without the suggested update mechanism of the workflow **124** might include inconsistencies or conflicts that might cause severe issues for the app development platform **118** when developing a corresponding app **120**. Also, in many cases, the trained function **132** without suggested update mechanism of the workflow **124** might lead to a messed-up and confusing workflow **124** that might be very hard for both a user and the app development platform **118** to interpreted in a meaningful way.

(67) In some examples, the application software component **106** and/or the processor **102** may further be configured to display the respective, determined position **130** to the user in the app development UI **116** and to capture the user's intent to approve at least one of the respective, determined position **130** in response to user interactions with the app development UI **116**.

(68) Displaying the respective, determined position **130** to the user and getting the user's approval to at least one of the respective, determine position(s) **130** may, in some examples, help to train and refine the trained function **132**. Over time, the trained function will improve its accuracy so that the likelihood that a determined position **130** fits well and is approved by the user is getting greater and greater.

(69) In further examples, the application software component **106** and/or the processor **102** may further be configured to move the workflow artifacts **122** of the workflow **124** following the inserted artifact **122a** along the determined flow direction **128** at least until the determined overlap **126** is removed.

(70) In such examples, (all) the workflow artifacts **122** following the inserted artifact **122a** may be

moved along the determined flow direction **128** at least until the determined overlap **126** is removed. The moved workflow artifacts **122** may include the following workflow artifact **122f**, i.e., the workflow artifact **122f** that follows the inserted artifact **122a**. This approach of updating the workflow **124** is simple and easy to implement, but nonetheless results in a well-arranged updated workflow **124'**. Such scenarios may be suitable for rather simple and linear workflows **124**, e.g., in which the workflow artifacts **122** following the inserted artifact **122a** are more or less arranged along one line, e.g., the determined flow direction **128**.

(71) in some examples, the application software component **106** and/or the processor **102** may further be configured to determine the overlap **126** of at least two of the workflow artifacts **122** caused by a previously moved workflow artifact **122m**; to determine the flow direction **128** of the workflow **124** from the preceding workflow artifact **122p** to the following workflow artifact **122f**, the preceding workflow artifact **122p** and the following workflow artifact **122f** preceding and following the previously moved workflow artifact **122m**, respectively; to determine at least one workflow artifact **122mm** of the workflow **124** that needs to be moved along the determined flow direction **128** to avoid the determined overlap **126**; and to determine the updated workflow **124'** by moving the respective, determined workflow artifact **122mm** along the determined flow direction **128** at least until the determined overlap **126** is removed.

(72) In these examples, in the previous step, the previously determined workflow artifact **122m** has already been moved, whereby the movement of this previously determined workflow artifact **122m** may cause the current overlap **126**. In this case, the previously described method may be applied again so that firstly, this new overlap **126** may be determined, secondly, the new flow direction **128** of the present workflow **124** may be determined, whereby the present workflow **124** corresponds to the previously updated workflow **124'** taking into account the movement of the previously moved workflow artifact **122m**. The new flow direction **128** takes into account the workflow artifact **122p** preceding the previously moved artifact **122m** and the workflow artifact **122f** following the previously moved artifact **122m**. Thirdly, at least one workflow artifact **122mm** may be determined that needs to be moved to avoid the determined current overlap **126**, and fourthly, the current workflow **124** may be updated to obtain an amended updated workflow **124'** by moving the respective determined workflow artifact **122mm** along the determined new flow direction **128** at least until the determined overlap **126** is removed.

(73) In this way, an overlap **126** that has previously been caused by moving a workflow artifact **122** to remove a previously existing overlap **126** may be removed. This procedure may be iterated, i.e., repeated again and again, until all iteratively caused overlaps **126** in the workflow **124** may be removed.

(74) In some examples, the application software component **106** and/or the processor **102** may further be configured to capture the user's intent to remove a selected workflow artifact **122r** from the workflow **124** in response to user interactions with the app development UI **116**; to remove the selected workflow artifact **122r** from the workflow **124** according to the captured user's intent; to determine a gap **134** between the preceding workflow artifact **122p** and the following workflow artifact **122f**, the preceding workflow artifact **122p** and the following workflow artifact **122f** preceding and following the removed workflow artifact **122r**, respectively; to determine the flow direction **128** of the workflow **124** from the preceding workflow artifact **122p** to the following workflow artifact **122f**; and to determine the updated workflow **124'** by moving the following workflow artifact **122f** in opposite direction to the determined flow direction **128** until the determined gap **134** is closed.

(75) Removing one of the workflow artifacts **122** may lead to a gap **134** between the artifacts **122p**, **122f** preceding and following the removed workflow artifact **122r**. Herein, a gap **134** may, in some examples, be understood as too much space between two neighboring workflow artifacts **122** of the workflow **124**, e.g., such that, e.g., an additional workflow artifact **122a** might be inserted in the gap **134** without causing an overlap **126**. Such gaps **134** may be avoided to maintain a well-

organized workflow **124** that, by way of example, also allows for easier readability to the user.

(76) After determining the flow direction **128** of the workflow **124** from the preceding workflow artifact **122_p** to the following workflow artifact **122_f**, the updated workflow **124'** may be obtained by moving the following workflow artifact **122_f** in opposite direction to the determined flow direction **128** until the gap **134** is closed. The opposite direction may hereby mean that the direction of movement of the following workflow artifact **122_f** is exactly opposed or rotated by 180° with respect to the determined flow direction **128**.

(77) In some examples, (all) the workflow artifacts **122** following the removed workflow artifact **122_r** or following the following workflow artifact **122_f** may be moved in opposite direction to the determined flow direction **128**. This approach of updating the workflow **124** is simple and easy to implement, but nonetheless results in a well-arranged updated workflow **124'**. Such scenarios may be suitable for rather simple and linear workflows **124**, e.g., in which the workflow artifacts **122** following the removed artifact **122_r** are more or less arranged along one line, e.g., the determined flow direction **128**.

(78) In some examples, the user intent may be to move one of the workflow artifacts **122** from an initial position to a final position within the workflow **124**. This user intent may be understood as deleting this specific workflow artifact **122** at the initial position and inserting the specific workflow artifact **122** at the final position in the workflow **124**. Herein, the removal of this specific workflow artifact **122** at the initial position in the workflow **124** may be understood as removing this specific workflow artifact **122** as the selected workflow artifact **122_r** from the workflow **124** at the initial position. The resulting gap **134** at the initial position may then be closed according to the approach described above.

(79) In some examples, the inserted workflow artifact **122_a** may be inserted into a loop **136** of workflow artifacts **122**. The loop **136** may have a loop size **138** and a loop border **139**. The application software component **106** and/or the processor **102** may further be configured to determine an overlap **126** of a workflow artifact **122** included by the loop **136** and the loop border **139**, the overlap **126** being caused by the workflow artifact **122_a** inserted into the loop **136**; and to determine the updated workflow **124'** by expanding the loop size **138** of the loop **136** along the determined flow direction **128** at least until the determined overlap **126** is removed.

(80) Herein, a loop **136** may be used to execute repeated actions including one or more workflow artifacts **122** may be visualized as a frame. For each iteration, the flow inside the loop **136** may be executed. In some examples, the loop **136** may be configured to iterate over a list or be based on a Boolean expression. The iteration over the list may include executing the workflow artifacts **122** of the loop **136** for each of the entries of the list. The iteration based on the Boolean expression may include executing the workflow artifacts **122** of the loop **136**, e.g., while a condition is true. In some examples, the loop **136** may contain all types of workflow artifacts **122**, e.g., also used in microflows or nanoflow, except for start events and end events that start or end the workflow **124**. Further, a loop **136** may contain workflow artifacts **122** corresponding to break events and continue events.

(81) In order to accommodate the workflow artifacts **122** included by the loop **136**, the loop **136** may have a certain loop size **138** and may be limited by a loop border **139** that may both be displayed in the app development UI **116** as a frame of a corresponding size.

(82) If the inserted workflow artifact **122_a** is inserted into the loop **136**, an overlap **126** of at least one of the workflow artifact **122** of the loop **136** and the loop border **139** may occur. First, this overlap **126** may be determined and then, an updated workflow **124** may be determined by expanding the loop size **138** and hence of the loop border **139** of the loop **136** along the determined flow direction **128** at least until the determined overlap **126** is removed. Herein, the flow direction **128** may be determined from the workflow artifact **122_p** preceding the inserted workflow artifact **122_a** to the workflow artifact **122_f** following the inserted workflow artifact **122_a**. Expanding the loop size **138** along the determined flow direction may, in some examples, mean that the start or

entry point of the loop **136** in the workflow **124** remains unchanged, whereas the endpoint or exit point of the loop **136** in the workflow **124** may be moved along the determined flow direction **128** thereby expanding or enlarging the loop size **138** and the loop border **139** until the determined overlap **126** is removed. In some examples, expanding the loop size **138** may involve expanding the loop border **139** along the determined flow direction **128** accordingly.

(83) By way of example, the application software component **106** and/or the processor **102** may further be configured to determine an overlap **126** of the expanded loop **136** and the workflow artifact **122f** following the loop **136**; to determine the flow direction **128** of the workflow **124** from the expanded loop **136** to the workflow artifact **122f** following the loop **136**; and to determine the updated workflow **124'** by moving the workflow artifact **122f** following the loop **136** along the determined flow direction **128** at least until the determined overlap **126** is removed.

(84) In this example, in the previous step, the loop size **138** has already been expanded to remove a previously existing overlap **126** between a workflow artifact **122** included by the loop **136** and the loop border **139**, whereby the expansion of the loop size **138** causes the current overlap **126**. In this case, a new overlap **126** may be determined, whereby now the expanded loop **136** with its expanded loop border **139** and the workflow artifact **122f** following expanded loop **136** may overlap. Then, the flow direction **128** may be determined that now takes into account these two items, namely the expanded loop border **139** and the workflow artifact **122f** following expanded loop **136**. Finally, the updated workflow **124'** may be determined by moving the workflow artifact **122f** following expanded loop **136** along the determined flow direction **128** at least until the determined overlap **126** is removed.

(85) In this way, an overlap **126** that has previously been caused by expanding the loop **136** may be removed.

(86) In some examples, the preceding workflow artifact **122p** may be a split artifact **140** starting partial flows **142** of the workflow **124**. The application software component **106** and/or the processor **102** may further be configured to determine the flow direction **128** of the workflow **124** from the following workflow artifact **122f** to the workflow artifact **122ff** following the following workflow artifact **122f**; and to determine the updated workflow **124'** by arranging the inserted artifact **122a** at an initial position **144** of the following artifact **122f** and by moving the following workflow artifact **122f** along the determined flow direction **128** at least until the determined overlap **126** is removed.

(87) In these examples, preserving the layout of the workflow **124** may be challenging. To meet this challenge, the flow direction **128** of the workflow **124** is determined by considering the workflow artifact **122f** following the inserted workflow artifact **122a** and the workflow artifact **122ff** following the workflow artifact **122f** following the inserted workflow artifact **122a**. In other words, the determination of the flow direction **128** is postponed or relocated by one couple of workflow artifacts **122** from the couple of workflow artifacts **122p-122f** to the couple of workflow artifacts **122f-122ff**.

(88) The updated workflow **124'** may then be determined by arranging the inserted artifact **122a** at the initial position **144** or **130** at which the following artifact **122f** was initially positioned. This following workflow artifact **122f** may then be moved along the determined flow direction **128** at least until the determined overlap **126** is removed. In some examples, the determined overlap **126** relate to an overlap **126** of at least two of the workflow artifacts **122** caused by the inserted workflow artifact **122a**. In many cases, the inserted workflow artifact **122a** and the following workflow artifact **122f** may overlap.

(89) The mentioned split artifact **140** may, by way of example, correspond to the decision workflow artifacts **122** explained above.

(90) In further examples, the following workflow artifact **122f** may be a merge artifact **148** merging partial flows **142** of the workflow **124**. The application software component **106** and/or the processor **102** may further be configured to determine the flow direction **128** of the workflow **124**

from the workflow artifact **122pp** preceding the preceding workflow artifact **122p** to the preceding workflow artifact **122p**; and to determine the updated workflow **124'** by moving the preceding workflow artifact **122p** in the opposite direction to the determined flow direction **128** at least until the determined overlap **126** is removed.

(91) Also in these examples, preserving the layout of the workflow **124** may be challenging. To meet the challenge, the updated workflow **124'** may be determined by moving the preceding workflow artifact **122p** in the opposite direction to the determined flow direction **128** at least until the determined overlap **126** is removed. Again, the opposite direction may hereby mean that the direction of movement of the preceding workflow artifact **122p** is exactly opposed or rotated by 180° with respect to the determined flow direction **128**. Herein, the preceding workflow artifact **122p** may be the workflow artifact **122p** that precedes the inserted workflow artifact **122a** and the workflow artifact **122pp** may precede the preceding workflow artifact **122p**. In some examples, all the workflow artifacts **122p** preceding the inserted workflow artifact **122a** may be moved in the opposite direction to the determined flow direction **128** at least until the determined overlap **126** is removed.

(92) In some examples, the updated workflow **124'** may further be determined by arranging the inserted artifact **122a** at the initial position **144** or **130** at which the preceding artifact **122p** was initially positioned.

(93) The mentioned merge artifact **148** may, by way of example, correspond to the merge workflow artifacts **122** explained above.

(94) in some examples, the application software component **106** and/or the processor **102** may further be configured to determine a moving borderline **146** in the workflow **124**. The moving borderline **146** intersects the preceding workflow artifact **122p** and is perpendicular to the determined flow direction **128**; and to determine an updated workflow **124'** by only moving one or more workflow artifacts **122** that are arranged in the workflow **124** at the same side of the moving borderline **146** as the inserted artifact **122a** or the removed workflow artifact **122r**.

(95) The use of the described moving borderline **146** may be advantageous for more complex or advanced workflows **124**. Such more complex workflows **124** may include curves at which workflow artifacts **122** may be arranged so that the workflow **124** may cross or intersect the determined moving borderline **146** once or several times. Imagine, for example, a workflow **124** with an S-shape or a Z-shape. The moving borderline may be a vertical line that splits this workflow **124** into the right half and the left half. It is obvious that such a workflow **124** crosses or intersect this moving borderline **146** three times, namely at the top, at the middle and at the bottom of the shape of the workflow **124**.

(96) The moving borderline **146** may be determined to intersect the workflow **124** at the preceding workflow artifact **122p** and may be perpendicular to the determined flow direction **128**. The updated workflow **124'** may then be determined by only moving artifacts **122** that are arranged at the same side of the moving borderline **146** as the inserted workflow artifact **122a** or the removed workflow artifact **122r**. In other words, in some examples, workflow artifacts that are arranged at the same side of the moving borderline **146** as the preceding workflow artifact **122p** may not be moved.

(97) This rather simple approach may turn out to be very efficient and failsafe. It is rather easy to implement and yet considerably contributes to preserve the layout of the workflow **124**.

(98) In further examples, the application software component **106** and/or the processor **102** may further be configured to deploy the developed app **120** including the updated workflow **124'** on a respective target device **150** of the app **120**.

(99) The (type of) target device **150** may, e.g., be a mobile platform, e.g. a smartphone, smartwatch, handheld, pad, laptop or the like, or a desktop device, e.g. including desktop computers, or other “smart” devices, e.g. smart television sets, fridges, home, or industrial automation devices. Smart television sets may e.g. be a television set with integrated Internet capabilities or a set-top box for

television that offers more advanced computing ability and connectivity than a contemporary basic television set. The different kinds of platforms may involve different operating systems, e.g., linux, unix, iOS, macOS, Microsoft Windows or the like. the user (“app developer”) developing the app **150** may be (and generally is) a different person than the user (“app customer”, “customer user” or “end user”) using or running the app **120** deployed on their target device **150**.

(100) Further, by way of example, the respective target device **150** may be or include a manufacturing operation management (MOM) system, a manufacturing execution system (MES), and enterprise resource planning (ERP) system, a supervisory control, and data acquisition (SCADA) system, or any combination thereof.

(101) By way of example, the app **120** may be deployed in the runtime of the respective target device **150**. Herein, the runtime of the respective target device **150** may be understood as runtime system, also called runtime environment, primarily implementing portions of an execution model. When treating the runtime system as distinct from the runtime environment (RTE), the first may be defined as a specific part of the application software (IDE) used for programming, a piece of software that provides the programmer a more convenient environment for running programs during their production (testing and similar) while the second (RTE) might be the very instance of an execution model being applied to the developed program that is itself then run in the aforementioned runtime system. The runtime environment may provide an environment in which programs, here the app **120**, run. This environment may address a number of issues including the management of application memory, how the program or the app **120** accesses variables, mechanisms for passing parameters between procedures, interfacing with the operating system, and otherwise. Typically, the runtime system will have some responsibility for setting up and managing the stack and heap, and may include features such as garbage collection, threads or other dynamic features built into the language.

(102) Further, an app **120** may be understood as deployed if the activities that are required to make this app **120** available for use by the app user on the respective target device **150** are completed. The app deployment process may include several interrelated activities with possible transitions between them. These activities may occur at the producer side (e.g., by the app developer) or at the consumer side (by the app user or end user) or both. In some examples, the app deployment process may include at least the release of the app **120** and the installation and the activation of the app **120**. The release activity may follow from the completed development process and is sometimes classified as part of the development process rather than deployment process. It may include operations required to prepare a system (here: e.g., the app development platform **118** or an on-line app store) for assembly and transfer to the computer system(s) (here: e.g., the respective target device **150**) on which it will be run in production. Therefore, it may sometimes involve determining the resources required for the system to operate with tolerable performance and planning and/or documenting subsequent activities of the deployment process. For simple systems, the installation of the app **120** may involve establishing some form of command, shortcut, script, or service for executing the software (manually or automatically) of the app **120**. For complex systems, it may involve configuration of the system—possibly by asking the end user questions about the intended app use, or directly asking them how they might like it to be configured—and/or making all the required subsystems ready to use. Activation may be the activity of starting up the executable component of software or the app **120** for the first time (that is not to be confused with the common use of the term activation concerning a software license, that is a function of Digital Rights Management systems).

(103) Once the app **120** has been deployed on the respective target device **150** or in the runtime of the respective target device **150**, the app **120** may be run or operated.

(104) By way of example, the application software component **106** and/or the processor **102** may further be configured to cause to apply the updated workflow **124'** of the developed app **120** to input data **152** to generate output data **154**; and to cause to analyze, monitor, operate and/or control

the respective target device **150**, or a device connected to the respective target device **150** using the generated output data **154** and/or to cause to analyze and/or monitor the respective target device's **150** user using the generated output data **154**.

(105) Once the app **120** has been deployed on the target device **150** or in the runtime of the target device **150**, the app **120** may be run or operated that may imply that the amended workflow **124'** of the app **120** may be put into action on (live) input data **152** to produce (actionable) output data **154**.

(106) By way of example, the respective target device **150** may not be connected to the app development platform **118** or to the internet, e.g., when or after the deployment of the developed app **120** on the respective target device **150** of the app **120**. Further, in some examples, the respective target device **150** may not be connected to the app development platform **118** or to the internet when or after the amended workflow **124'** of the developed app **120** is applied to the input data **132**.

(107) In some examples, the target device **150** may include or be the app development platform **118**.

(108) In an example embodiment, the app **120** may be deployed on a respective target device **150**. In some examples, the respective target device **150** may be physically connected or communicatively connected to the other device or connected such, that the respective target device **150** may at least detect the input data **152** from the other device, e.g., by optically inspecting the other device. The other device may, in some examples, be or include a sensor, an actuator, such as an electric motor, a valve or a robot, an inverter supplying an electric motor, a gear box, a programmable logic controller (PLC), a communication gateway, and/or other parts or components relating to industrial automation products and industrial automation in general. The respective target device **150** may be part of a complex production line or production plant, e.g., a bottle filling machine, conveyor, welding machine, welding robot, etc.

(109) In some examples, if the other device belongs to a lower level of the automation pyramid, such as the sensor/actuator or the field level, then the respective target device **150** may belong to a higher level of the automation pyramid, such as field level or the control level.

(110) In this context, the respective target device **150** may be caused or triggered, e.g., by the app development platform **118**, to apply the amended workflow **124'** to the input data **152** to generate the output data **154**. The generated output data **154** may be used to analyze, monitor, operate and/or control the respective target device **150** or the other device. In further examples, the respective target device **150** may be caused or triggered, e.g., by the app development platform **118**, to analyze, monitor, operate and/or control the respective target device **150** or the other device using the generated output data **154**. In some examples, the mentioned steps may directly be performed by the app development platform **118**.

(111) In further examples, the respective target device **150** may also be caused or triggered, e.g., by the app development platform **118**, to apply the updated workflow **124'** to the input data **152** to generate the output data **154**. The generated output data **154** may be used to analyze and/or monitor the respective target device's **150** user. In further examples, the respective target device **150** may be caused or triggered, e.g., by the app development platform **118**, to analyze and/or monitor the respective target device's **150** user using the generated output data **154**. In such more exotic examples, the respective target device **150** may be or include a smartphone, smartwatch, handheld, pad, laptop or the like and the other device may be a human, e.g., the end user of the respective target device **150**, or an animal or plant. The human's, the animal's or the plant's health, behavior, etc. may be analyzed or monitored using the amended workflow **124'** and the app **120**. In some examples, the mentioned steps may directly be performed by the app development platform **118**.

(112) In further examples, only new overlaps **126** may be detected and in some examples, old overlaps that existed previously may not be considered or tried to be resolved.

(113) By way of example, the following rule set may be applied, whereby objects may be understood as the above-mentioned workflow artifacts **122**: Rule 1: If the new object overlaps with

objects (indirectly) connected to the preceding object, then we should move the new object. This rule may avoid distorting the layout of the workflow **124**. Exception: Allow moving overlapped connected objects, if their direction is the same as the nudging or moving direction, and they are that side of the new object. Rule 2: if the overlapped objects are not connected to preceding objects, then move those instead of moving the new object. Rule 3: If the new object overlaps objects that are not connected to preceding objects, that are far side of origin, then move the new object.

(114) The rules may be run in the above order.

(115) As explained above, moving one the workflow artifacts **122** may result in new overlaps **126** that should also be resolved.

(116) Preceding objects should, in most examples, not be moved.

(117) The described the application software component **106** and/or the processor **102** may carry out an analogous method of managing an app **120**, for example developing an app **120** including updating a workflow **124** of the app **120**.

(118) Further, a computer-readable medium **160** that may include a computer program product **162** is shown in FIG. **1**. The computer program product **162** may be encoded with executable instructions, that when executed, cause the computer system **100** or and/or the app development platform **118** to carry out the described method.

(119) For the sake of completeness, the two app development UIs **116** depicted in FIG. **1** are briefly explained. In the upper app development UI **116**, the insertion of the additional workflow artifact **122a** in the workflow **124** is depicted. The workflow **124** may already include the preceding workflow artifact **122p** and the following workflow artifact **122f**. An overlap **126** of the inserted workflow artifact **122a** and the following workflow artifact **122f** may be determined that may be caused by the insertion of the additional workflow artifact **122a**. Further, the flow direction **128** of the workflow **124** may be determined. The flow direction **128** may be directed from the preceding workflow artifact **122p** to the following workflow artifact **122f**. The following workflow artifact **122f** may be determined to be the workflow artifact **122m** that may be needed to be moved to remove the determined overlapped **126**. The following workflow artifact **122f** may need to be moved along the determined flow direction **128**, as indicated with the dashed arrow.

(120) In the lower app development UI **116**, the status of the workflow **124** after the insertion of the additional workflow artifact **122a** is depicted. And updated workflow **124'** may be obtained by moving the inserted workflow artifact **122a** along the determined flow direction **128** until the overlapped **126** is removed. According to the updated workflow **124'**, the previous workflow artifact **122p** may be followed by the inserted workflow artifact **122a** that may be followed by the following workflow artifact **122f**.

(121) By way of example, the additional workflow artifact **122a** may be put at the initial position of the following workflow artifact **122f** or in the vicinity the initial position of the following workflow artifact **122f**, e.g., towards the preceding workflow artifact **122p**, to obtain the amended workflow **124'**.

(122) With reference to FIG. **2**, a functional block diagram of another example computer system or data processing system **100** is depicted that facilitates managing apps **120**, for example developing an app **120** including updating a workflow **124** of the app **120**.

(123) In this example, a position **130** in the workflow **124** may be determined at which to insert the additional workflow artifact **122a** using the captured user's intent and a trained function **132**. By way of example, the determined position **130** may displayed to a user and the user may approve the determined position **130** by their interactions with the app development UI **116**.

(124) Further, the app **120** including the updated workflow **124'** may be deployed on a target device **150**. The updated workflow **124'** of the developed and deployed app **120** may be applied to input data **152** to generate output data **154**. By way of example, the input data **152** may be provided by the target device **150**, the other device, a device connected to the target device **150** or the target device's user. In some examples, the generated output data **154** may be used to analyze, monitor,

operate and/or control the target device **150** or the device connected to the target device **150**. In other examples, the generated output data **154** more may be used to analyze and/or monitor the target device's user.

(125) FIG. **3** depicts a flow diagram of an example methodology that facilitates managing an app in a product system.

(126) In the upper half of FIG. **3**, a workflow **124** is depicted that may include a preceding workflow artifact **122p** and a following workflow artifact **122f**. A flow direction **128** of the workflow **124** may be determined to point from the preceding workflow artifact **122p** to the following workflow artifact **122f**. An additional workflow artifact **122a** may be inserted into the workflow **124** and may cause an overlap **126** of the additional workflow artifact **122a** with the following workflow artifact **122f**. The overlap **126** may be determined and it may further be determined that the following workflow artifact **122f** may be the workflow artifact **122m** to be moved along the determined flow direction **128** to avoid the determined overlap **126**.

(127) The lower half of FIG. **3** depicts the updated workflow **124'** that may be obtained by moving the determined workflow artifact **122m** that is in this case the following workflow artifact **122f** along the determined flow direction **128** at least until the determined overlapped **126** is removed.

According to the updated workflow **124'**, the previous workflow artifact **122p** may be followed by the inserted workflow artifact **122a** that may be followed by the following workflow artifact **122f**.

(128) By way of example, the additional workflow artifact **122a** may be put at the initial position of the following workflow artifact **122f** or in the vicinity the initial position of the following workflow artifact **122f**, e.g., towards the preceding workflow artifact **122p**, to obtain the amended workflow **124'**.

(129) FIG. **4** depicts a flow diagram of another example methodology that facilitates managing an app in a product system.

(130) In the upper half of FIG. **4**, a workflow **124** is depicted that may include a preceding workflow artifact **122p**, a workflow artifact **122r**, and a following workflow artifact **122f**. A flow direction **128** of the workflow **124** may be determined to point from the preceding workflow artifact **122p** to the following workflow artifact **122f**. The user may choose to remove the workflow artifact **122r** that may cause a gap **134** between the preceding workflow artifact **122p** and the following workflow artifact **122f**.

(131) The lower half of FIG. **4** depicts the updated workflow **124'** that may be obtained by moving the following workflow artifact **122f** (which is in this case the workflow artifact **122m** to be moved) in the opposite direction to the determined flow direction **128** at least until the determined gap **134** is closed. According to the updated workflow **124'**, the previous workflow artifact **122p** may be followed by the following workflow artifact **122f**.

(132) FIG. **5** depicts a flow diagram of a further example methodology that facilitates managing an app in a product system.

(133) In the upper half of FIG. **5**, a more complex workflow **124** is depicted that may include several sequentially arranged workflow artifacts **122pp**, **122p**, **122f** and **122ff**. The workflow artifact **122ff** is a split artifact **140** starting two partial flows **142** of the workflow **124**. The upper partial flow **142** only includes the workflow artifact **122fffa** and the lower partial flow **142** includes another sequence of workflow artifacts **122fffb**, **122-4fb**, **122-5fb**, **122-6fb**. The workflow has a U-shape. The opening of the U points to the left.

(134) An additional workflow artifact **122a** may be inserted into the workflow **124** and may cause an overlap **126** of the additional workflow artifact **122a** with the following workflow artifact **122f**. The overlap **126** may be determined and it may further be determined that the following workflow artifact **122f** may be the workflow artifact **122m** to be moved along the determined flow direction **128** to avoid the determined overlap **126**.

(135) Further, a moving borderline **146** may be determined in the workflow **124**. The moving borderline **146** intersects the preceding workflow artifact **122p** and is perpendicular to the

determined flow direction **128**. Herein, the workflow artifacts **122pp**, **122p**, **122-5fb**, and **122-6fb** are arranged at the opposite site of the moving borderline **146** as the inserted workflow artifact **122a**. In some examples, for updating the workflow **124** to obtain the updated workflow **124'**, only workflow artifacts **122** may be moved that are arranged in the workflow **124** at the same site of the moving borderline **146** as the inserted workflow artifact **122a**.

(136) The lower half of FIG. 5 depicts the updated workflow **124'** that may be obtained accordingly, i.e., by moving only workflow artifacts **122** that are arranged in the workflow **124** at the same site of the moving borderline **146** as the inserted workflow artifact **122a**, i.e., in this case the workflow artifacts **122f**, **122ff**, **140**, **122fffa**, **122fffb**, **122-4fb**. Accordingly, the workflow artifacts **122pp**, **122p**, **122-5fb**, and **122-6fb** may not be moved to obtain the updated workflow **124'**.

(137) By way of example, the additional workflow artifact **122a** may be put at the initial position of the following workflow artifact **122f** or in the vicinity the initial position of the following workflow artifact **122f**, e.g., towards the preceding workflow artifact **122p**, to obtain the amended workflow **124'**.

(138) FIG. 6 depicts a flow diagram of another example methodology that facilitates managing an app in a product system.

(139) In the upper half of FIG. 6, a more complex workflow **124** is depicted that may include a workflow artifact **122pp** that is followed by a split artifact **122p**, **140** that may start three partial flows **142**. The upper partial flow **142** may include two sequentially arranged workflow artifacts **122f** and **122ff**. The middle partial flow **142** may only include one workflow artifact **122sp2**, and the lower partial flow **142** may also only include one workflow artifact **122sp3**.

(140) An additional workflow artifact **122a** may be inserted into the upper partial flow **142** of the workflow **124** and may cause an overlap **126** of the additional workflow artifact **122a** with the following workflow artifact **122f**. In this example, the flow direction **128** of the workflow **124** may be determined from the following workflow artifact **122f** to the workflow artifact **122ff** following the following workflow artifact **122f**. The overlap **126** may be determined and it may further be determined that the following workflow artifact **122f** may be the workflow artifact **122m** to be moved along the determined flow direction **128** to avoid the determined overlap **126**. Further, an updated workflow **124'** may be determined by arranging the inserted artifact **122a** at an initial position **144** of the following artifact **122f** and by moving the following workflow artifact **122f** along the determined flow direction **128** at least until the overlap **126** of the inserted workflow artifact **122a** and the following workflow artifact **122f** is removed.

(141) The lower half of FIG. 6 depicts the updated workflow **124'** that may be obtained by moving the following workflow artifact **122f** along the determined flow direction **128** and then the workflow artifact **122ff** following the following artifact **122f**. Hence, the upper partial flow **142** now includes three sequentially arranged workflow artifacts **122a**, **122f** and **122ff**. The layout of the original workflow **124** could be preserved.

(142) FIG. 7 depicts a flow diagram of yet another example methodology that facilitates managing an app in a product system.

(143) In the upper half of FIG. 7, a workflow **124** is depicted that may include two partial flows **142**. The upper partial flow **142** may include two sequentially arranged workflow artifacts **122pp** and **122p** and the lower upper partial flow **142** may include one workflow artifact **122pf2**. The two partial flows **142** may be merged by the following workflow artifact **122f** that is a merge artifact **148**. An additional workflow artifact **122a** may be inserted into the upper partial flow **142** of the workflow **124** and may cause an overlap **126** of the additional workflow artifact **122a** with the previous workflow artifact **122p**.

(144) The flow direction **128** of the workflow **124** may be determined to point from the workflow artifact **122pp** preceding the preceding workflow artifact **122p** to the preceding workflow artifact **122p**. The updated workflow **124'** may then be obtained by moving the preceding workflow artifact

122p in the opposite direction to the determined flow direction **128** at least until the determined overlap **126** is removed.

(145) The lower half of FIG. 7 depicts the updated workflow **124'** that may be obtained by moving the previous workflow artifact **122p** and the workflow artifact **122p** that precedes the previous workflow artifact **122p** accordingly. Hence, the upper partial flow **142** now includes three sequentially arranged workflow artifacts **122pp**, **122p** and **122a**. The layout of the original workflow **124** could be preserved.

(146) By way of example, the additional workflow artifact **122a** may be put at the initial position of the preceding workflow artifact **122p** or in the vicinity the initial position of the preceding workflow artifact **122p**, e.g., towards the workflow artifact **122pp** preceding the preceding workflow artifact **122p**, to obtain the amended workflow **124'**.

(147) FIG. 8 depicts a flow diagram of another example methodology that facilitates managing an app in a product system.

(148) In the upper third of FIG. 8, a workflow **124** is depicted that may include the first workflow artifact **122pp** that may be followed by a loop **136** including to sequentially arranged workflow artifacts **122p** and **122f**. The loop **136** may be followed by a last workflow artifact **122lf**. The loop may have loop size **138**. An additional workflow artifact **122a** may be inserted into the loop **136** that may cause an overlap of the inserted workflow artifact **122a** with the previous workflow artifact **122p**.

(149) The flow direction **128** from the preceding workflow artifact **122p** to the following workflow artifact **122f** may be determined and updated workflow **122'** may be determined by moving the following workflow artifact **122f** (which may correspond to the workflow artifact **122m** to be moved) along the determined flow direction **128** to avoid the determined overlap **126**.

(150) By way of example, the additional workflow artifact **122a** may be put at the initial position of the preceding workflow artifact **122f** or in the vicinity the initial position of the following workflow artifact **122f**, e.g., towards the preceding workflow artifact **122p**, to obtain the amended workflow **124'**.

(151) This updated workflow **124'** is depicted in the center third of FIG. 8. The moved, following workflow artifact **122f**, **122m** that is included by the loop **136** now overlaps with the loop border **139**. This overlap **126** may be determined as well as the flow direction **128** pointing from the following workflow artifact **122f** to the workflow artifact **122lf** following the loop **136**. The updated workflow **124''** may be obtained by expanding the loop size **138** along the determined flow direction **128** at least until the determined overlap **126** is removed. Herein, expanding the loop size **138** may involve expanding the loop border **139** along the determined flow direction **128** accordingly. The expansion of the loop **136**, the loop size **138**, and the loop border **139** is depicted in the lower third of FIG. 8 with the dashed arrow.

(152) This updated workflow **124''** is depicted in the lower third of FIG. 8 as well as in the upper half of FIG. 9.

(153) FIG. 9 depicts a flow diagram of yet another example methodology that facilitates managing an app in a product system.

(154) The upper half of FIG. 9 depicts the updated workflow **124''** that may be obtained by the procedure depicted in FIG. 8 and described above. Expanding the loop size **138** and the loop border **139** may lead to an overlap **126** of the expanded loop border **139** and the workflow artifact **122lf** following the loop **136**. The flow direction **128** may be determined to point from the expanded loop **136** to the workflow artifact **122lf** following the loop **136**. Then, the updated workflow **124'''** may be obtained by moving the workflow artifact **122lf** (which may now be the workflow artifact **122m** to be moved) following the loop **136** along the determined flow direction **128** at least until the determined overlap **126** is removed.

(155) This updated workflow **124'''** is depicted in the lower half of FIG. 9.

(156) Referring now to FIG. 10, a methodology M that facilitates managing apps, such as

developing an app including im-porting a trained function, is depicted. The method may start at **M02** and the methodology may include several acts carried out through operation of at least one processor.

(157) These acts may include an act **M04** of providing an app development user interface (UI) to a user for developing the app; an act **M06** of displaying at least two workflow artifacts of a workflow of the app to the user in the app development UI; an act **M08** of capturing the user's intent to insert an additional workflow artifact into the workflow in response to user interactions with the app development UI; an act **M10** of inserting the additional workflow artifact into the workflow according to the captured user's intent; an act **M12** of determining an overlap of at least two of the workflow artifacts caused by the inserted workflow artifact; an act **M14** of determining a flow direction of the workflow from the preceding workflow artifact to the following workflow artifact, the preceding and the following workflow artifact preceding and following the inserted workflow artifact, respectively; an act **M16** of determining at least one workflow artifact of the workflow that needs to be moved along the determined flow direction to avoid the determined overlap; an act **M18** of determining an updated workflow by moving the respective, determined workflow artifact in the direction of the determined flow direction at least until the determined overlap is removed; an act **M20** of displaying at least the preceding workflow artifact, the inserted workflow artifact, and the following workflow artifact to the user in the app development UI; and an act **M22** of developing the app through the app development UI by using the updated workflow. At **M24** the methodology may end.

(158) The methodology **M** may include other acts and features discussed previously with respect to the computer-implemented method of managing an app, for example developing an app including updating a workflow of the app.

(159) FIG. 11 depicts a block diagram of a data processing system **1000** (also referred to as a computer system) in which an embodiment may be implemented, for example, as a portion of a product system, and/or other system operatively configured by software or otherwise to perform the processes as described herein. The data processing system **1000** may include, for example, the computer or IT system or data processing system **100** mentioned above. The data processing system depicted includes at least one processor **1002** (e.g., a CPU) that may be connected to one or more bridges/controllers/buses **1004** (e.g., a north bridge, a south bridge). One of the buses **1004**, for example, may include one or more I/O buses such as a PCI Express bus. Also connected to various buses in the depicted example may include a main memory **1006** (RAM) and a graphics controller **1008**. The graphics controller **1008** may be connected to one or more display devices **1010**. It should also be noted that in some embodiments one or more controllers (e.g., graphics, south bridge) may be integrated with the CPU (on the same chip or die). Examples of CPU architectures include IA-32, x86-64, and ARM processor architectures.

(160) Other peripherals connected to one or more buses may include communication controllers **1012** (Ethernet controllers, WiFi controllers, cellular controllers) operative to connect to a local area network (LAN), Wide Area Network (WAN), a cellular network, and/or other wired or wireless networks **1014** or communication equipment.

(161) Further components connected to various busses may include one or more I/O controllers **1016** such as USB controllers, Bluetooth controllers, and/or dedicated audio controllers (connected to speakers and/or microphones). Various peripherals may be connected to the I/O controller(s) (via various ports and connections) including input devices **1018** (e.g., keyboard, mouse, pointer, touch screen, touch pad, drawing tablet, trackball, buttons, keypad, game controller, gamepad, camera, microphone, scanners, motion sensing devices that capture motion gestures), output devices **1020** (e.g., printers, speakers) or any other type of device that is operative to provide inputs to or receive outputs from the data processing system. Also, many devices referred to as input devices or output devices may both provide inputs and receive outputs of communications with the data processing system. For example, the processor **1002** may be integrated into a housing (such as a tablet) that

includes a touch screen that serves as both an input and display device. Further, some input devices (such as a laptop) may include a plurality of different types of input devices (e.g., touch screen, touch pad, keyboard). Also, other peripheral hardware **1022** connected to the I/O controllers **1016** may include any type of device, machine, or component that is configured to communicate with a data processing system.

(162) Additional components connected to various busses may include one or more storage controllers **1024** (e.g., SATA). A storage controller may be connected to a storage device **1026** such as one or more storage drives and/or any associated removable media, that may be any suitable non-transitory machine usable or machine-readable storage medium. Examples include nonvolatile devices, volatile devices, read only devices, writable devices, ROMs, EPROMs, magnetic tape storage, floppy disk drives, hard disk drives, solid-state drives (SSDs), flash memory, optical disk drives (CDs, DVDs, Blu-ray), and other known optical, electrical, or magnetic storage devices drives and/or computer media. Also, in some examples, a storage device such as an SSD may be connected directly to an I/O bus **1004** such as a PCI Express bus.

(163) A data processing system in accordance with an embodiment of the present disclosure may include an operating system **1028**, software/firmware **1030**, and data stores **1032** (that may be stored on a storage device **1026** and/or the memory **1006**). Such an operating system may employ a command line interface (CLI) shell and/or a graphical user interface (GUI) shell. The GUI shell permits multiple display windows to be presented in the graphical user interface simultaneously, with each display window providing an interface to a different application or to a different instance of the same application. A cursor or pointer in the graphical user interface may be manipulated by a user through a pointing device such as a mouse or touch screen. The position of the cursor/pointer may be changed and/or an event, such as clicking a mouse button or touching a touch screen, may be generated to actuate a desired response. Examples of operating systems that may be used in a data processing system may include Microsoft Windows, Linux, UNIX, iOS, and Android operating systems. Also, examples of data stores include data files, data tables, relational database (e.g., Oracle, Microsoft SQL Server), database servers, or any other structure and/or device that is capable of storing data, that is retrievable by a processor.

(164) The communication controllers **1012** may be connected to the network **1014** (not a part of data processing system **1000**), that may be any public or private data processing system network or combination of networks, as known to those of skill in the art, including the Internet. Data processing system **1000** may communicate over the network **1014** with one or more other data processing systems such as a server **1034** (also not part of the data processing system **1000**). However, an alternative data processing system may correspond to a plurality of data processing systems implemented as part of a distributed system in which processors associated with several data processing systems may be in communication by way of one or more network connections and may collectively perform tasks described as being performed by a single data processing system. Thus, it is to be understood that when referring to a data processing system, such a system may be implemented across several data processing systems organized in a distributed system in communication with each other via a network.

(165) Further, the term “controller” means any device, system, or part thereof that controls at least one operation, whether such a device is implemented in hardware, firmware, software or some combination of at least two of the same. It should be noted that the functionality associated with any particular controller may be centralized or distributed, whether locally or remotely.

(166) In addition, data processing systems may be implemented as virtual machines in a virtual machine architecture or cloud environment. For example, the processor **1002** and associated components may correspond to a virtual machine executing in a virtual machine environment of one or more servers. Examples of virtual machine architectures include VMware ESXi, Microsoft Hyper-V, Xen, and KVM.

(167) Those of ordinary skill in the art will appreciate that the hardware depicted for the data

processing system may vary for particular implementations. For example, the data processing system **1000** in this example may correspond to a computer, workstation, server, PC, notebook computer, tablet, mobile phone, and/or any other type of apparatus/system that is operative to process data and carry out functionality and features described herein associated with the operation of a data processing system, computer, processor, and/or a controller discussed herein. The depicted example is provided for the purpose of explanation only and is not meant to imply architectural limitations with respect to the present disclosure.

(168) Also, it should be noted that the processor described herein may be located in a server that is remote from the display and input devices described herein. In such an example, the described display device and input device may be included in a client device that communicates with the server (and/or a virtual machine executing on the server) through a wired or wireless network (which may include the Internet). In some embodiments, such a client device, for example, may execute a remote desktop application or may correspond to a portal device that carries out a remote desktop protocol with the server in order to send inputs from an input device to the server and receive visual information from the server to display through a display device. Examples of such remote desktop protocols include Teradici's PCOIP, Microsoft's RDP, and the RFB protocol. In such examples, the processor described herein may correspond to a virtual processor of a virtual machine executing in a physical processor of the server.

(169) As used herein, the terms "component" and "system" are intended to encompass hardware, software, or a combination of hardware and software. Thus, for example, a system or component may be a process, a process executing on a processor, or a processor. Additionally, a component or system may be localized on a single device or distributed across several devices.

(170) Also, as used herein a processor corresponds to any electronic device that is configured via hardware circuits, software, and/or firmware to process data. For example, processors described herein may correspond to one or more (or a combination) of a microprocessor, CPU, FPGA, ASIC, or any other integrated circuit (IC) or other type of circuit that is capable of processing data in a data processing system, that may have the form of a controller board, computer, server, mobile phone, and/or any other type of electronic device.

(171) Those skilled in the art will recognize that, for simplicity and clarity, the full structure and operation of all data processing systems suitable for use with the present disclosure is not being depicted or described herein. Instead, only so much of a data processing system as is unique to the present disclosure or necessary for an understanding of the present disclosure is depicted and described. The remainder of the construction and operation of data processing system **1000** may conform to any of the various current implementations and practices known in the art.

(172) Also, it should be understood that the words or phrases used herein should be construed broadly, unless expressly limited in some examples. For example, the terms "include" and "comprise," as well as derivatives thereof, mean inclusion without limitation. The singular forms "a," "an" and "the" are intended to include the plural forms as well, unless the context clearly indicates otherwise. Further, the term "and/or" as used herein refers to and encompasses any and all possible combinations of one or more of the associated listed items. The term "or" is inclusive, meaning and/or, unless the context clearly indicates otherwise. The phrases "associated with" and "associated therewith," as well as derivatives thereof, may mean to include, be included within, interconnect with, contain, be contained within, connect to or with, couple to or with, be communicable with, cooperate with, interleave, juxtapose, be proximate to, be bound to or with, have, have a property of, or the like.

(173) Also, although the terms "first", "second", "third" and so forth may be used herein to describe various elements, functions, or acts, these elements, functions, or acts should not be limited by these terms. Rather these numeral adjectives are used to distinguish different elements, functions or acts from each other. For example, a first element, function, or act could be termed a second element, function, or act, and, similarly, a second element, function, or act could be termed

a first element, function, or act, without departing from the scope of the present disclosure.

(174) In addition, phrases such as “processor is configured to” carry out one or more functions or processes, may mean the processor is operatively configured to or operably configured to carry out the functions or processes via software, firmware, and/or wired circuits. For example, a processor that is configured to carry out a function/process may correspond to a processor that is executing the software/firmware, that is programmed to cause the processor to carry out the function/process and/or may correspond to a processor that has the software/firmware in a memory or storage device that is available to be executed by the processor to carry out the function/process. It should also be noted that a processor that is “configured to” carry out one or more functions or processes, may also correspond to a processor circuit fabricated or “wired” to carry out the functions or processes (e.g., an ASIC or FPGA design). Further the phrase “at least one” before an element (e.g., a processor) that is configured to carry out more than one function may correspond to one or more elements (e.g., processors) that each carry out the functions and may also correspond to two or more of the elements (e.g., processors) that respectively carry out different ones of the one or more different functions.

(175) In addition, the term “adjacent to” may mean: that an element is relatively near to but not in contact with a further element; or that the element is in contact with the further portion, unless the context clearly indicates otherwise.

(176) Although certain embodiment of the present disclosure has been described in detail, those skilled in the art will understand that various changes, substitutions, variations, and improvements disclosed herein may be made without departing from the spirit and scope of the disclosure in its broadest form.

(177) None of the description in the present patent document should be read as implying that any particular element, step, act, or function is an essential element, that must be included in the claim scope: the scope of patented subject matter is defined only by the claims.

Claims

1. Computer-implemented method of creating an app, wherein a computer system is configured to execute the following steps of the method: providing, by at least one processor, an app development user interface (UI) to a user for developing the app; displaying, by the app development UI at least two workflow artifacts of a workflow of the app to the user; capturing, by the app development UI, an intent of the user to insert an additional workflow artifact into the workflow in response to user interactions with the app development UI; inserting, by the at least one processor, the additional workflow artifact into the workflow according to the captured user's intent; determining, by the at least one processor, an overlap of at least two of the at least two workflow artifacts caused by the inserted workflow artifact; determining, by the at least one processor, a flow direction of the workflow from a preceding workflow artifact to a following workflow artifact, the preceding workflow artifact and the following workflow artifact preceding and following the inserted workflow artifact, respectively; determining, by the at least one processor, at least one workflow artifact of the workflow which needs to be moved along the determined flow direction to avoid the determined overlap; determining, by the at least one processor, an updated workflow by moving the determined workflow artifact along the determined flow direction at least until the determined overlap is removed; displaying, by the app development UI, at least the preceding workflow artifact, the inserted workflow artifact, and the following workflow artifact to the user; developing, by the at least one processor, the app through the app development UI by using the updated workflow; determining, by the at least one processor, a moving borderline the workflow, wherein the moving borderline intersects the preceding workflow artifact and is perpendicular to the determined flow direction; determining, by the at least one processor, an updated workflow by only moving one or more workflow artifacts which are

arranged in the workflow at the same side of the moving borderline as the inserted artifact or a removed workflow artifact; and deploying and running the developed app comprising the updated workflow for implementation in a runtime of the developed app in a respective target device.

2. The Computer-implemented method according to claim 1, further comprising: determining, by the at least one processor, at least one position in the workflow at which to insert the additional workflow artifact using the captured user's intent and a trained function.

3. The Computer-implemented method according to claim 2, further comprising: displaying, in the app development UI, the determined at least one position to the user; and capturing, with the app development UI, the user's intent to approve at least one of the determined at least one position in response to user interactions.

4. The Computer-implemented method according to claim 1, further comprising: moving, by the at least one processor, the workflow artifacts of the workflow following the inserted artifact along the determined flow direction at least until the determined overlap is removed.

5. The Computer-implemented method according to claim 1, further comprising: determining, by the at least one processor, the overlap of at least two of the workflow artifacts caused by a previously moved workflow artifact; determining, by the at least one processor, the flow direction of the workflow from the preceding workflow artifact to the following workflow artifact, the preceding workflow artifact and the following workflow artifact preceding and following the previously moved workflow artifact, respectively; determining, by the at least one processor, at least one workflow artifact of the workflow which needs to be moved along the determined flow direction to avoid the determined overlap; and determining, by the at least one processor, the updated workflow by moving the determined workflow artifact along the determined flow direction at least until the determined overlap is removed.

6. The Computer-implemented method according to claim 1, further comprising: capturing the user's intent to remove a selected workflow artifact from the workflow in response to user interactions with the app development UI; removing the selected workflow artifact from the workflow according to the captured user's intent; determining, by the at least one processor, a gap between the preceding workflow artifact and the following workflow artifact, the preceding workflow artifact and the following workflow artifact preceding and following the removed workflow artifact, respectively; determining, by the at least one processor, the flow direction of the workflow from the preceding workflow artifact to the following workflow artifact; and determining, by the at least one processor, the updated workflow by moving the following workflow artifact in opposite direction to the determined flow direction until the determined gap is closed.

7. The Computer-implemented method according to claim 1, wherein the inserted workflow artifact is inserted into a loop of workflow artifacts, the loop having a loop size and a loop border, the method further comprising: determining, by the at least one processor, an overlap of a workflow artifact comprised by the loop and the loop border, the overlap being caused by the workflow artifact inserted into the loop; and determining, by the at least one processor, the updated workflow by expanding the loop size of the loop along the determined flow direction at least until the determined overlap is removed.

8. The Computer-implemented method according to claim 7, further comprising: determining, by the at least one processor, an overlap of the expanded loop and the workflow artifact following the loop; determining, by the at least one processor, the flow direction of the workflow from the expanded loop to the workflow artifact following the loop; and determining, by the at least one processor, the updated workflow by moving the workflow artifact following the loop along the determined flow direction at least until the determined overlap is removed.

9. The Computer-implemented method according to claim 1, wherein the preceding workflow artifact is a split artifact starting partial flows of the workflow, the method further comprising: determining, by the at least one processor, the flow direction of the workflow from the following

workflow artifact to the workflow artifact following the following workflow artifact; and determining, by the at least one processor, the updated workflow by arranging the inserted artifact at an initial position of the following artifact and by moving the following workflow artifact along the determined flow direction at least until the determined overlap is removed.

10. The Computer-implemented method according to claim 1, wherein the following workflow artifact is a merge artifact merging partial flows of the workflow, the method further comprising: determining, by the at least one processor, the flow direction of the workflow from the workflow artifact preceding the preceding workflow artifact to the preceding workflow artifact; determining, by the at least one processor, the updated workflow by moving the preceding workflow artifact in the opposite direction to the determined flow direction at least until the determined overlap is removed.

11. The Computer-implemented method according to claim 1, wherein the workflow intersects the determined moving borderline at least twice, and wherein the workflow includes a U-shape, an S-shape, or a Z-shape.

12. The Computer-implemented method according to claim 1, further comprising: applying, by the at least one processor, the updated workflow of the developed app to input data to generate output data; and analyzing, monitoring, and/or controlling the respective target device, or a device connected to the respective target device using the generated output data and/or analyzing and/or monitoring the respective target device's user using the generated output data.

13. A non-transitory computer-readable medium including machine-readable instructions stored therein that when executed by a computer system, cause the computer system configured to execute the following steps to: provide an app development user interface (UI) to a user for developing the app; display at least two workflow artifacts of a workflow of the app to the user in the app development UI; capture the user's intent to insert an additional workflow artifact into the workflow in response to user interactions with the app development UI; insert the additional workflow artifact into the workflow according to the captured user's intent; determine an overlap of at least two of the at least two workflow artifacts caused by the inserted workflow artifact; determine a flow direction of the workflow from a preceding workflow artifact to the following workflow artifact, the preceding and the following workflow artifact preceding and following the inserted workflow artifact, respectively; determine at least one workflow artifact of the workflow which needs to be moved along the determined flow direction to avoid the determined overlap; determine an updated workflow by moving the respective, determined workflow artifact along the determined flow direction at least until the determined overlap is removed; display at least the preceding workflow artifact, the inserted workflow artifact, and the following workflow artifact to the user in the app development UI; develop the app through the app development UI by using the updated workflow; determine a moving borderline in the workflow, wherein the moving borderline intersects the preceding workflow artifact and is perpendicular to the determined flow direction; determine an updated workflow by only moving one or more workflow artifacts which are arranged in the workflow at the same side of the moving borderline as the inserted artifact or the removed workflow artifact; and deploy and run the developed app comprising the updated workflow for implementation during runtime on a respective target device.
